

Contact

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(LinkedIn)

Top Skills

AI Software Development
Data-Driven Product Development
AI/ML in Financial Products

Languages

English (Native or Bilingual)
French (Limited Working)

Certifications

Certified ScrumMaster (CSM)
Certified Scrum Product Owner
(CSPO)

Kelly Barbeau

Director of Product @ Kiavi | Fintech Product Management
Charlotte, North Carolina, United States

Summary

I thrive at the intersection of fintech, AI, and automation, transforming complex lending and underwriting processes into seamless, scalable solutions. With a background in software engineering and product leadership, I bring a data-driven and technical approach to solving real-world financial challenges. At Kiavi, as Director of Product, I manage a team of Product Managers and drive AI-powered underwriting automation that improves borrower experience and operational efficiency. By integrating machine learning models, vendor data, and real-time decisioning, we've reduced manual review time by 20%, accelerated loan approvals, and enhanced risk assessment accuracy. Previously, as Director of Product at Accion Opportunity Fund, I spearheaded a complete overhaul of the loan origination system, transitioning from legacy infrastructure to a modern, microservice-driven tech stack. Throughout my career, I've worked at the intersection of lending, risk modeling, and digital transformation, optimizing financial products for both borrowers and businesses.

Core Skills:

- AI & ML in Lending: Driving automation in underwriting and risk assessment
- Data-Driven Decision Making: Leveraging analytics to improve lending speed & efficiency
- Cross-Functional Leadership: Aligning engineering, risk, sales & underwriting teams
- Fintech Innovation: Scaling digital lending products with modern tech stacks

I'm passionate about mentoring PMs, building fintech products, and solving complex problems with technology. If you're in the fintech space and interested in discussing AI in lending, underwriting automation, or digital transformation, let's connect! In my free time, you'll find me skiing, hiking, or explore new places with my daughter and husband.

Experience

Kiavi
4 years

Director of Product Management

February 2025 - Present (1 year 4 months)

Charlotte, North Carolina, United States

Kiavi empowers real estate investors with modern technology, timely capital to fund opportunities, and the confidence required to unlock the value of America's aged homes.

- Leading and mentoring a team of product managers, driving strategic vision, execution, and professional development to enhance cross-functional collaboration and business impact.
- Owning the product strategy and roadmap for underwriting and risk automation, balancing business growth with compliance and operational efficiency while collaborating with engineering, risk, sales, and underwriting teams. Recent projects we've delivered: automated KYC leveraging Plaid to reduce fraud risk, instant ARV estimator leveraging our proprietary ARV model to increase borrower deal confidence, GenAI scope of work document extraction to improve customer experience.
- Driving automation in underwriting by integrating AI-driven decisioning models and external data to deliver instant loan approvals, reducing manual review time by 20% and improving borrower experience.
- Influencing executive-level decision-making by aligning product initiatives with company OKRs, using data-driven insights to improve lending speed, risk assessment accuracy, and team productivity.

Principal Product Manager

June 2022 - February 2025 (2 years 9 months)

Charlotte, North Carolina, United States

Accion Opportunity Fund

Director of Product Management

January 2021 - June 2022 (1 year 6 months)

Charlotte, North Carolina, United States

Accion Opportunity Fund provides small business owners access to capital, networks, and coaching. Their mission is to advance the economic well-being of working people by helping them earn, save, and invest in their future.

- Directed the complete technical rewrite and rebrand of the loan origination system, leading a transition to a modern, scalable React.js and AWS Lambda infrastructure.

- Spearheaded the design and implementation of a risk scorecard API, enabling more accurate borrower assessments based on cash flow rather than traditional credit scores.
- Improved internal processes through the introduction of CI/CD pipelines and QA automation.
- Led a cross-functional team in delivering a 20% improvement in loan origination time through product enhancements.

Praxent

3 years 7 months

Client Partner

November 2019 - December 2020 (1 year 2 months)

Charlotte, North Carolina, United States

Praxent is a fintech design, engineering, and implementation partner. Praxent works with fintechs at every stage of their product lifecycle in banking, wealth management, lending, and insurance.

- Led cross-functional teams (engineering, design, QA) to deliver fintech solutions across lending, insurance, and real estate.
- Owned product strategy, roadmap, and backlog while translating business needs into technical requirements (user stories, sitemaps, workflows).
- Managed \$3M+ in client portfolios, optimizing gross margins (closed 2020 at 65%).
- Delivered 92% of projects on time & under budget, overseeing a \$250K+ monthly budget.
- Spearheaded sales engagements, from initial pitch to contract signing, and supported contract negotiations to drive revenue growth.
- Defined and implemented best practices for the PMO, enhancing team efficiency and scalability.

Key Projects & Leadership

- Bungalo (PropTech): Led product development from idea to MVP in <8 months while staying under budget.
- Austin Capital Bank (Banking): Led tech audit and process optimization, advising their Scrum team.
- Insurance Benefits Platform: Built a compliance-driven benefits management system with real-time eligibility processing.

Senior Product Manager

May 2019 - November 2019 (7 months)

Austin, Texas Area

Product Manager
June 2017 - May 2019 (2 years)
Austin, Texas Area

Nuance Communications

1 year 4 months

Technical Consultant
September 2016 - April 2017 (8 months)
Montreal, Canada Area

Nuance is a computer software technology corporation that provides speech recognition, artificial intelligence and imaging applications. During my time at Nuance, I worked in the Professional Services division and focused primarily on implementing the FreeSpeech application for Nuance's financial services clients.

- Promoted within 9 months from Software Engineer to Technical Consultant; transitioned from implementation to development lead.
- Led development for 6 enterprise implementations of FreeSpeech, a biometric authentication platform used by 25,000+ call center agents globally.
- Designed and refined product architecture based on client needs, collaborating with stakeholders to enhance usability and efficiency.
- Spearheaded KPI tracking improvements, enabling financial services clients to measure FreeSpeech's impact on fraud reduction and call efficiency.
- Developed backend features (Java, Angular 2) for a web application used by 14 of the top 15 U.S. banks while following Agile best practices.
- Supported sales as a technical SME, advising on product specifications and leading client kickoff meetings.

Software Engineer
January 2016 - September 2016 (9 months)
Montreal, Canada Area

Education

Wake Forest University School of Business
Master of Business Administration - MBA · (August 2024 - May 2026)

McGill University

Bachelor of Software Engineering, Faculty of Engineering · (August
2011 - December 2015)

American School of Paris
Graduate · (2005 - 2011)